

A British 17th-century scientist at the forefront of the Scientific Revolution, Robert Hooke excelled in various roles, including physicist, biologist, inventor, and architect. He discovered the law of elasticity, invented a new microscope, helped to redesign London after the Great Fire, and published the first popular science book.

MILESTONES

ATTENDS UNIVERSITY

Earns place on a choral scholarship at Christ Church College, Oxford University, in 1653.

SCIENTIFIC ASSISTANT

Works as an assistant to Robert Boyle from 1655 and discovers a love of science; joins elite academic circle.

HOOKE'S LAW

Discovers the law of elasticity in 1660; applies his research into springs to improve clockmaking.

BEST-SELLING BOOK

Uses improved microscope for scientific investigation; publishes hugely popular *Micrographia* in 1665.

ARCHITECTURAL WORK

His skills in design and artistry aid Christopher Wren in the restoration of the City of London in 1666.

Robert Hooke was born on the Isle of Wight in 1635. He was often sick as a child, resulting in a sporadic formal education; instead, he engaged in varied pursuits, including painting, model-making, and music. He was highly intelligent and took a great interest in mechanical devices—he famously dismantled a brass clock, then built a working replica out of wood. In 1648, Hooke's father died, and with his inheritance, Hooke funded his own education at Westminster School; aged 18, he gained a place at Oxford University. Hooke's formative education was unorthodox and eclectic, but it formed a springboard that would launch the career of one of the great polymaths of the 17th century. Despite his renown, no contemporary portraits of Hooke survive, but several artists have made posthumous ones.

Wonderful world of science

A lack of funds at Oxford led Hooke to take on part-time work, first as assistant to the physician and chemist Thomas Willis, then later to the natural philosopher Robert Boyle (see pp.66–69). At this time, Hooke's own natural aptitude for science began to flourish and set him on a path toward great future scientific endeavor. Boyle

Hooke discovered the law of elasticity: that the extension and compression of a spring is proportional to the force applied to it. He first published his law as an anagram, which unscrambled read "as the extension, so the force" in Latin.

